

Dark Waters

In my world, all beings *towered*. Blades of grass were a forest. A puddle was a lake. Pebbles? Boulders to be scurried around, scurry, scurry, scurry to one's next destination. The ground beneath me was damp with recent rain, mud swelling into cliffs, a land slide if I choose less than the safest route. With this world encompassing every sense I possess, it's sometimes all too easy to lose sight of the bigger picture, forget myself in the moment. And, in all truth, I could forget who I am and live a simple life for all eternity, like so many others before me. After all, that is the only reason I came to be as a god. Because another god deemed me to be a god. And so I was a god. Yet a god in an animal body all the same.

I often wonder if the last god enjoys their new life as a thoughtless canine, whirling about in circle after circle, chasing a tail she can never catch. I believe she chose the form of a golden retriever to end her 'stewardship' over the earth, passing on as her mind grew wearier than her body. My body is a black dot. If I chose to move on to another form, to end my time in eternity, I do not think I shall remain as I am. Perhaps something with hooves could be a more appealing option?

I shake myself, mentally, sharpening my mind to a task that slips away too easily as thoughts battle for dominance. I am too small for the enormity of intelligence swallowing me up, a whale taking Jonah into the very pit of its belly. This skill is to be harnessed, wielded, but only when the will says so, for a limited span of time only. That does not prey on my mind as much as it used to, to claim such power and such weakness in a disproportionate balance. I scamper along the branch of a tree, black legs flying: tap-tap-tap-tappa-tappa-tap-tap. Quicker and quicker, there's not a soul that can catch me. As an immortal

The branch shudders dramatically and I pause, antenna quivering. A squirrel has jumped on to my branch, claws scraping. Any other of my kind, the body I inhabit, would have seen his end there and then, for all the weight we can lift. I, however, have no such fear. As the monster towers above me, a mound of fluff and claws that could crush me into a crisp splatter of guts and matter, I merely twitch an antenna. A nose dips, nostrils quivering, as the squirrel sniffs, lifts its head back up, beady eyes as respectful as those belonging to a squirrel can be, and goes on his way. He scarpers down the branch, clinging to the frailer tips where spring buds are tucked in tight in pink and green before dropping to the branch below, finding his own way back to whatever home a squirrel will call home. He's probably looking for the food he buried, the last stores running low as spring slinks in.

Do you understand my power, or lack of, yet? As the squirrel tumbles from branch to branch, both lacking grace and embodying the essential fluidity of it, I perch at the point that the bark rounds down to a dizzying drop, even for one of the human persuasion, a normal size. The greatest power comes in the smallest forms. Have you come to your own conclusion? And are you correct? Oh, I quiver in anticipation of your sheer *shock*, your reel of repulsion! You would crush me under your heel and yet I would live on and laugh at your short-lived folly until the next time my power came around.

For, dear reader, your god is but an ant.

It is not a bad life, if each day rolling into one another until there is no difference between them can be called a life. I cannot deal in minutes or hours as each one passes so swiftly to me, any focus I have on the larger life around me, the planet earth on which I have been

placed to walk. Sometimes I wonder if I would have chosen this fate. My will was not brought into the matter – I simply woke up this way and went on my way, much like that squirrel. There are certain perks to the ‘job’, as it is though.

I anthropomorphised animals, whispering in their ears how to walk on two legs with the intelligence of soft-skinned humans. The dogs pricked up their ears and lived elongated lives, lips twisting into something halfway between the human and canine, though it was only the select species that I turned. My favourites, if I am perfectly honest with you. There were many more that I could have turned, but power has its limits and that one was for my own personal entertainment. The humans did not enjoy that one so much, their world invaded with a concoction of the primitive and the advanced. Still, that was one for them to learn.

I only wanted to see what they would do. Even I sometimes become bored.

Constraints to my power run rife, however, as you may have already guessed. I, of course, have no natural enemy. Nature flows around me and the humanity us gods created, each adding our own flair to the spectrum, well they do an excellent job of destroying themselves. That’s how the two-legged animals were added to the mix. I thought they would add a little flavour, given time. My power builds over time and can be expended in part or all at once in the span of a minute. This may not seem like a very great stretch of time but it has served us well so far in our stewardship, as frustrating as it may be running through one’s daily life after life. It is truly amazing what one can accomplish in under a minute. With seconds to spare, even.

Unconvinced? Perhaps you would not understand, dear reader. I took one minute to pen this text, ink blurring on to parchment at a speed even I had not thought possible. It’s easy to believe things are impossible, when you live life as an ant. Yet the power I hold is the very greatest of all.

I was not alone in the forest that day, however, and sought to exercise the little power I’d regained in my time of rest. My body thrummed with the urge to spend it and, as reckless as a god could be, I hurled myself into the arms of fate – my own design, of course. Luckily, I had a target not too far away at all, removing any requirement for travel. I peered down from my roost, antenna quivering as if to discern more information from the sight I found on the forest floor below.

A wolf adorned with thick, black fur perched on the rickety bench below my tree, head cradled in his paws as he dug the points of his elbows into his meatier thighs. His jeans were ripped across both knees but that was not something that I could pay too much mind to, being the fashion of the day. He also wore a strip of green plastic around his left wrist like a bracelet, something which I also put down to fashion. There was no telling what the furries would find fashionable next, being of a more eccentric mind than humans. I liked them eccentric.

Pulling speed to my legs, I laced my form down the tree in a flash, bark whipping past in a fleeting, private moment of revelling at my own strength. Oh, I was stronger indeed. It had to be spent, it simply had to. I never held on to my power for too long.

When my feet hit the ground, they were no longer the black nubs of an ant, suited to an ant’s lot in life and survival. Instead of my natural ant, I stood tall as a horse, hooves spread apart

to ground myself in the new form. Balance came less naturally to me with hooves and I ground my new, blunt teeth together experimentally, ears twitching in the place of antenna atop my head. Transformation came in the blink of a human eye and I had access to any form I desired for whichever needs I deemed the temporary change necessary. Inhaling slowly, my great chest expanded, lungs filling with crisp, clean woodland air. It had rained recently and the peaty smell of earth infused the air, dampness welcome after the droughts. The transformation would not last forever, however. I would have to be as swift as a striking snake as time outside my chosen form was limited. I would only have a short amount of time before I would seemingly disappear before the wolf's eyes, only shrinking back to the little ant I was.

That day, I chose a palomino stallion for my form, keeping true to male as I felt myself of that persuasion. There were some gods that slipped between genders as they pleased but there was definitely a masculine note to my mind as I shifted from shape to shape, going about a god's work. I mimicked the gait of the horse whose image I had stolen, clip-clopping down a path so thick with moss that it was difficult to see the man made route beneath. Nature liked to reclaim and I was not one to halt her in her tracks.

Brushing the cream mane off the back of my neck where it half-stuck into a simple t-shirt – something similar to what youths of the day would wear but devoid of brand or slogan – I approached the wolf from the side. I eyed the bow of his neck with a snort and flick of my ear, though he did not move an inch in response to my approach, remaining as still and silent as one who had become a statue.

I paused two feet away.

“You are not one I’ve seen around these parts before.”

The wolf stiffened, tension lining the span between his shoulder blades. He shook, hunched over himself and tucked his tail down over his rump. I looked at him strangely. It was exceptionally rare indeed to find a wolf with no wag to his tail. And the tip of his tail boasted a fluffy white streak too, beautiful in its subtlety and design. Mentally, I frowned, keeping my faux muzzle as serene as a pond on a still summer's day. There should be a wag to it, as was tradition with furries of his kind. He should not differ from the designed norm, it was unnatural.

I sat on the bench beside him. It wasn't as if he needed the additional space. Stretching out my legs, I put my new paws together behind my head, the hoofed fingertips touching through the mess of my mane. He would talk soon enough, I had no concern with that. While he found his voice, I stared up through the canopy of deciduous trees. It would have been the ideal location for a nap, if I had wanted to chance sleeping in the open in a mortal form. Those faced greater vulnerabilities than my true form, my ant.

Eventually, the wolf stirred, sliding apart his fingers to look out at me through the gap like a cub playing peek-a-boo. Though his jeans were torn, the navy hooded sweatshirt he wore was in immaculate condition, boasting that ‘new clothing’ scent that was impossible for a furry with a more sensitive nose than a human to miss even outside. The amber orbs stared unblinking, piercing. I yawned.

“What do you want?” He asked through his paws, words muffled.

Pricking only the one ear, I glanced at him from the corner of my eye, busy enjoying the play of sunshine across my muzzle.

“You speak now then, do you?”

I affected his manner of speaking the best I could, assuming that he spoke as most other young humans and ‘furries’. The words were clumsy on my tongue, however, and I grimaced. He coughed what could have been a laugh into his paws and sat upright in a scrape of fabric, slouching back on the bench.

“So what if I do? Speak. What if I speak, huh?”

Rolling my eyes, I settled my shoulder blades more comfortably against the back of the bench. Something was engraved on it but I paid it no mind for the time being as it was only a minor inconvenience to comfort.

“Just seems rather rude to be sitting here and not making conversation with a fur who wants your attention, that’s all I’m saying.”

I flipped my paws up dismissively and went back to enjoying the warming sunshine. The wolf rolled his shoulders back and said nothing, sparing a glance for the lush canopy of leaves above. Though the breeze rustled through them, cooling the sting of sun, there was not another mortal soul for many miles that I could sense. And my senses were *impeccable*.

Chest heaving in a sigh, the wolf stared down at his bare hind paws – an unusual choice for an anthro to go bare-pawed, and wriggled his toes, claws digging tiny rivets into the dry dirt. I licked my lips, relaxing in the quiet, birdsong filtering around.

Patience.

“Why are you sitting here?”

Eventually speaking up when one presumed the silence grew too pressing, the wolf turned his head to look at me, eyes narrowed. Suspicion spun within and it was easy to see how another could fall into those depths, drowning until they tumbled head over paws into the wolf’s arms. He blinked, lashes long and feminine in an otherwise masculine muzzle with a hard line to the jaw. Even my breath caught.

You would have been beautiful, wolf...

“You looked like you were upset.”

That instantly got the wolf’s back up and the hackles at the back of his neck rose, lips curling back unconsciously to show a flash of white fangs.

“And what if I fucking was?” He growled, ears pinned flat to his skull. “That’s none of your business and you shouldn’t stick your nose into things you don’t understand.” He paused. “Prick.”

“Now, now.” His spirit was amusing. “Is that any way to speak to your elders?”

“Screw that,” he said. “You can’t be, what, any older than me. So don’t talk to me like I’m a pup. Piss off if you’re not going to say anything useful, taking up space here, like.”

The whites of the wolf’s eyes gleamed and I stifled a chuckle, wondering if the little wolf thought he could take me on. Mortals were entertaining to toy with. It was why we were so different, the mortals and the gods. And why the mortals were my playthings and nothing more.

What an excellent choice it had been to create the furies!

“What is your name?” I asked casually, hardly dissuaded by his childish outburst.

The wolf tilted his head to one side, ears pricking up from his skull.

“Why do you want to know?”

I shrugged.

“I like to know who I’m talking to.”

He hesitated, thinking the request over with undue deliberation. I almost rolled my eyes where he could see; mortal forms were too expressive for my liking at times, working against me when I wanted to work with them.

“I’m Ty,” he said at last, putting the words out there as if revealing a great secret.

“And you? Who are you?”

“Deon.”

It was not the first name that came to mind but a play on Dion – Dionysus, a trickster from human Greek mythology. Like me, he could take on many forms as a shape shifter and it was said in their tails that you could never be confident as to what he would do next. I rubbed a paw across my muzzle, wrinkling my nose to conceal my snort as a sneeze. Such fools. Their myths and legends had long been surpassed by a far deadlier source.

“Why are you out here alone, Ty?” I probed with just the right measure of sympathy in my tone. “You must have walked *hours* to get this far out from civilisation.”

“I could ask the same about you.”

“Well, I asked first.”

The wolf laughed, muzzle wrinkling.

“You’re a funny one, you know that?”

I inclined my head and he shook his in return, some of the tension slipping from the slope of his shoulders. Surreptitiously, I eased closer to him on the bench, so slowly that he did not notice my motion.

“So what are you doing out here?”

I nudged him further. He was no good to me if I did not understand how I could best use this strange furry for my own amusement. Simple chatter would not entertain me for long.

Waving a paw, the wolf rubbed the back of his neck and shifted uncomfortably, ducking his muzzle.

“I don’t know... Just had to get away from it all. You know how it all gets too much sometimes?”

I nodded, though I did not understand, and he continued unheeded, words spilling forth as if he had held them close for too long a time.

“I went out hiking this morning, thought I would walk and jog for as far as I could go in half a day and spend the rest of the day getting back to where I started, back at the city. But, once I started, I just kept going and going and going and didn’t want to stop. Out here, there’s no one, no one but me. Well,” he added as if as an afterthought, “and you now.”

“I hope I am not too much of a disturbance.”

He shook his head and held up his paws, palms towards me.

“No...no,” he reassured quickly, too swift to wish to appease me. “You’re not a disturbance at all, though it’s weird to see someone else out here. You’re the first person or furry that I’ve seen all day long. I thought I’d be alone out here.” He picked at the hole in his jeans. “Completely alone.”

“You brought no backpack with you to go hiking,” I noted, poking holes.

The wolf slumped forward, paws dangling between his thighs.

“I didn’t intend on going home again.” He closed his eyes. “I didn’t need a bag. I didn’t need anything.”

Ah. That was it then, was it? I could have rubbed my paws together in glee. These were some of the most entertaining to play with, truly they were.

“What do you mean?” I feigned curiosity, though I already knew his type. “Why wouldn’t you want to go home again? You already said you were going to go out for half a day and then hike back? Didn’t you just end up out for longer than you expected? And shouldn’t you be heading back now?”

The questions tied his tongue and the wolf scratched his neck as if to buy himself time to think up a suitable response.

“Well...I mean...” He fumbled. “Didn’t really think about that, you know? Sometimes it’s, ah, nicer out here than it is in the city, want to stay out here in the forest longer, stay here.”

Letting him talk himself into a corner, I smiled privately, cupping my grin behind a paw before injecting once the wolf trailed off, eyes wide and as lost as a puppy’s.

“You want to kill yourself.”

“No!” He yelped, back ramrod straight and tail finally twitching. “Why the hell would you say something like that? That’s messed up, fucking insane.”

I pursed my lips, the ridges above my eyes pulling skin taut as I raised eyebrows that would have been there on a human, though I could still make the ‘face’ desired. Clearly unsettled by my lack of retort, the wolf scrabbled for words.

“I mean, that’s absolutely barking mad, you’ve got to know that,” he tried, clutching at straws. “Crazy talk, ridiculous. Are you thick or something to come up with an idea like that when all I said was that I was out here hiking?”

There were no words that I needed to say so I remained silent longer, letting the seconds stretch into minutes while the wolf fidgeted. He looked between me and the near line of birch trees, though no inspiration leapt out at him with a jester’s smile to provide him all the answers he needed. A robin trilled a warning song in the tree above and I watched my squirrel friend from some time earlier streak through the thinnest of branches like an acrobat.

A notion struck the wolf and he jerked his head back towards me, paw landing on the bench between us as he leaned in, lips parted a second earlier than speech poured out of his chunky muzzle.

“Why?” His eyes gleamed. “Are you out here to kill yourself? Is that why you think that’s what I’m out here for?”

I looked at him levelly, paws folded neatly in my lap.

“Not at all. I am out here to enjoy this fine, summer day. And you are out in the woods to end your life.”

The fight seeped out of the wolf like water trickling down the drain and he snarled, lips curling back ferociously. On a feral, the four-legged version, of his kind, it may have been terrifying. On him, it was nearing cute. He could not do a single thing to me and yet he thought he was in the right, that he knew better than me. Leaning forward to rest my elbows on my knees, I didn’t even pretend to me imperious this time.

“Fine...” The wolf glared, lips turning down at the corners of his long muzzle. “You going to stop me?”

“I think you’ve already stopped yourself.”

Growling, the wolf shook his head.

“How? I’m still going to do it, you know. Just because you’re here doesn’t mean anything. You can bugger off and be none the wiser to this. Leave. Get on with *your* life and stop interfering with mine.”

I laughed impolitely into my paw, tail swishing against the bench. For a wolf, his intelligence was lacking.

“If you want to kill yourself, why did you say ‘didn’t’ instead of ‘don’t’ earlier? Seems like you no longer plan on offing yourself after all that.”

The wolf huffed and scratched the back of his neck.

“Now you’re going into technicalities of words... Does it matter which words I did or didn’t use?”

“It all matters in the grand scheme of life and death, my dear.”

He flinched at my choice of words, balking visibly and inching away along the bench. This time, however, I followed, leaning in with an earnest gleam to my eyes. I knew how to paint my expressions perfectly by this point in life.

“Who are you?” He asked, wariness lining the tension to his muscles. “A name does not tell me *who* you are, not really.”

The corners of my ears crinkled in and I tossed my head, flipping my messy, native mane from one side of my neck to the other in a casually equine move. My heart pounded as the wolf slipped away and my power danced at my fingertips, begging to be used. I closed my eyes.

“Does it matter if you are going to kill yourself?” I, cleverly, even if I do say so myself, deflected. “I am nothing more than a stranger in a world that you are never going to see again in a very short span of time.”

The wolf visibly deflated, exhaling all breath from his lungs in a heavy sigh. He

“Yeah...” He licked his lips. “You’re probably right there. Even if you are here, there is no reason to not go ahead with things.” He eyed me. “Seems like you understand.”

“Oh, I do.” I looked up at the canopy of leaves, trees stretching friendly arms above. “There’s not a whole lot to life besides living and dying. Trust me, I should know.”

Falling silent, I waited to see what the wolf would do, how he would move the conversation to the next level. Or if he would back off entirely. Who could tell until the event itself transpired?

Picking apart the fibres in his jeans with his gaze, the wolf hooked his claws beneath the ragged edge slashed across one of his knees. The cut in the denim yawned open like a gaping wound, tufts of dark fur protruding as if to escape. His tongue lashed out, moistening his black nose, and he hardened the line of his lips, rubbing his chest with his free paw. Yanking,

he ripped the denim, sound unnatural in the birdsong of the forest, while I, fascinated, observed every nuance of his self-destruction. Tearing the hole into his jeans further, he dug his claws into the gap with a sharp inhalation and grimaced. I widened my eyes.

“Why are you hurting yourself?”

“To make it hurt less. I don’t really want to go. I want to live. I...” He hesitated. “I just don’t want to live like this. It’s not worth it.”

“What is the life you have then?”

“Nothing much, nothing special.” He shook his head. “Sharing a flat with a friend, or at least he was my friend. We don’t talk too much anymore.” The wolf’s ears drooped and his tail tucked further in between his legs. “He’s always busy.”

“Wouldn’t he miss you?”

The wolf barked a laugh that echoed through the trees and shook his head, leaning back against the bench. It seemed that nothing more than that derisive bark was required to convey his point and I stifled my snort, wishing to join him in his derision. Mortals were fickle. I could only imagine how swiftly the aforementioned friend’s allegiances shifted once the wolf had taken his first step on the slow, downward spiralling staircase into depression. Fair weather, as they said, attracted friendships that did not stand the test of thunderstorms. The wolf should know.

Something – a rodent, if my ears read its tread truly – rustled through the undergrowth, darting into thicker territory, and half-caught the wolf’s attention, if but for a fraction of a second. My lips twitched. Whether the wolf wished it or not, he was still attached to the mortal world, holding on by the tips of his claws and a will so strong that it was a wonder that he had ever meandered his way out to the forest to die.

Perhaps I would help him along his way. It was only right and just for one in my position to lend a helping hand or paw when opportunity presented itself. I was strong enough to set this poor, young soul on the right path.

I inhaled deeply and the wolf jerked, twitching himself out of thought, and half-turned his muzzle towards me, lips pursed curiously.

“He’d notice I’m gone but I reckon that’s about it, nothing more to it really than that. He’s got other things to think about and more important things on his mind than a twat like me.”

The wolf sat quietly, paws folded in his lap, ears twitching as he listened to the birds singing through the trees. Every so often, his eyes flitted up to track the flight of one small bird or another – they were of little importance to me – and cracked his first smile at a brown wren with a neat, upward pointing tail, so small and well camouflaged that she could have not been there at all. His keen eyes caught her, however, and sent her on her way with a wolf yip and tickling wave of his tail.

Bearing the weight into my hooves, I dug rivets into the dirt.

“Anyway...yeah, you’re right, if you’d like to hear that.” He said at last. “I’m not going to kill myself. At least...not today. I can’t anymore. I’m put off now.”

I pressed my tongue to the roof of my mouth but forced the rising comment to not pass my lips as the wolf went on, animated in how he now moved his arms and paws as he talked. Looking straight ahead, the wolf’s eyes brightened with fresh light and life as he talked, talking himself into what had been a terrifying notion when I had approached his bench. I smiled and bobbed my muzzle, scratching the coarse equine whiskers on my chin. Sometimes mortals almost did the work for me, which was not entirely a bad thing. This would be simpler than expected.

The wolf groaned and pressed his muzzle into his palm, ears slanting back halfway as heat rose to his muzzle beneath his thicker coat of fur. Though one could not see a blush under fur it had quickly become evident after their introduction that a blush could be seen in the mannerisms of furries when they were embarrassed by happenings. The ears were a certain ‘tell’.

“Today, you stopped a stranger from committing suicide, with nothing more than your presence alone. Big horse that you are, you’ve done a good deed today, yessiree.” He chuckled hoarsely, mirthless laughter rasping in his throat. “Ain’t that something? Hey? Ain’t that something now?”

He leaned in, bumping my shoulder with his own, and I curled the paw on the far side of my body into a fist, biding my time. My power itched to be used and I clenched my jaw, stilling the flick of my tail through sheer willpower alone as my strength swelled like the rise of the wind, peaking to a howl. Dappled sunlight danced across our legs.

Now.

“Isn’t it a waste?”

He started.

“A what?”

“You know.” I shrugged. “Not killing yourself. You’ve gone to a lot of effort in this endeavour. Isn’t it a waste to drag yourself all the way out here and not do what you came here to do?”

I plucked a thick stem of grass from between my hooves and put it between my lips, chewing languidly so the juices were released. Gaping at me, the wolf shook his head, torso twisted across the bench so that he faced me, eyes so wide that I feared for a comical moment that they may pop out of his skull altogether.

“What...are you talking about?” He said slowly, bringing a paw up to cup his cheek, fur sticking up where he had raked his claws through it. “I... What are you telling me to do?”

My eyes hardened, drawing on mental strains of power and sending them flying towards the wolf like moths under the cover of an evening lull. He did not feel my strength wrap around

his throat but he sensed his leave him and curved his spine forward, forearms on his thighs as if he no longer had the

Some would have said it was a waste of a god's power to use it in such a way. I would only retaliate that life was excessively boring for a god. I had to have a bit of sport from time to time. I placed a gentle, soothing paw on the wolf's thigh to keep him in place, digesting what I said as I worked in the background to turn his thoughts to a darker, more permanent path. He was already halfway there.

In times before, humans hunted deer for meat. Now they farmed their livestock. Gods cultivated the world. Bored gods hunted souls, human or furry, for their amusement.

Immoral? Who are you to say?

"I mean, you've told me now quite clearly that you want to die," I continued, flipping my paw. "It seems that, perhaps, this is not the life for you. This presence in the world is not the one you are meant to have. Something, somewhere, has gone terribly awry."

The words were only there as a cover while I worked my 'magic' – could that be called, as was the human turn of phrase, *kitsch*? – veins of earth's essence, the otherworldly creation, twisting and weaving the beautifully grotesque. Slowly, I wove a net about the wolf, trapping him within so that, in my mind's eye where the true power lay, I could barely see him for a mist of silvery-grey, as fine as a spider's web. Power crackled along the veins, sparking from one line to another, and the wolf struggled to breathe, chest expanded against a constriction he could neither see or understand. The mental hand around his throat *squeezed*.

The beauty of the day could not save him now.

"Yeah..." His eyes were unfocused, glassy. "Maybe...you're right. Maybe..."

He slurred his words as he trailed off and I smiled, knowing he would not register the contrasting expression from me in the mortal world. The wolf was another in my collection of deaths and one more in my grasp. It was bad luck that he had come across me on the wrong day and the wrong time but – was that not simply the very nature of life? Only the strongest and those with the luck of the draw survived to fight another day. It did not matter how strong the wolf was when a god wrapped a thread around their throat and increased the pressure with their smallest finger alone. He stood no chance, no chance at all.

Clutching the fur on the back of his neck in memory of a scruff, the wolf moaned, his tone laced with mane. Though he tried to speak, no words were forthcoming and only a pained gurgle burst from his lips in a bubble of spittle that drooled down his chin. He did not even wipe it away, staring out into space with the look of one hypnotised. My chest vibrated in a chuckle, swallowed down deep so as not to spoil the illusion, and I placed a careful paw on his shoulder, solidifying my hold on him. The end was near – I could taste it on the tip of my tongue, a rare vintage.

"Only you can rectify this injustice, Ty," I said, rubbing my fingers in soothing circles around his shoulder, bone and muscle. "It truly would be a crime to continue living as you are. You deserve better, so much better."

The wolf shook his head, lost in the motion as if he could shake his head enough times and everything would be all right again. Sunlight glanced obnoxiously off his muzzle, highlighting tiny flecks of grey in his fur that would have been stunning in their imperfection at any other time. He ground his teeth together and threw back his head as if to howl, but only a muffled groan slipped out, muzzle shaking from how hard he clenched his jaw. Nothing would ever be right again for this wolf.

I leaned in closer, arm brushing his with a feather-light touch. He flinched away, shuddering from my touch, as cold as the snows of the deepest north.

“Why not make life better for yourself, Ty?” I whispered. “In death.”

Tying a knot in the thread of power, I sealed the web around my little wolf and trimmed myself neatly free of his depressing influence. I snipped our connection as deftly as one may cut a piece of string, leaving the wolf shuddering in his own misery, tail a dead stick hanging down from the bench with not a scrap of life left in it. I applied myself carefully to the task of severance, completing the tier by moving away from the wolf on the bench with a scrape of fabric on wood, coarse and unyielding. One would not wish any lingering thoughts from those set on ending their lives to remain in the system, of course not.

Head in his paws, the wolf whimpered, running his paws through the fur on his head and neck, claws cutting through the fur to the skin. Rivulets of blood drew lines through his dark fur, soaking the individual hairs with a metallic tang.

My job was complete.

“Well...” I stood and clapped the dumbfounded wolf on the shoulder, my smile mirroring his sadness. “You take care now. You got to do what’s right for you. There’s nothing more to it than that. Fuck anyone else.”

I made good my exit before my equine form failed me, tail swishing merrily to my back as I left the wolf to contemplate his fate. I had stayed before to watch my friends go to their bitter end but, this time, I trusted the wolf to his own devices. All alone in the forest, he could have had drugs in the pocket of his jeans, provided the holes did not extend so far up that he had lost them on his way to his death. That would have been unfortunate. Rope was an easy one – he could be planning to hang himself. Teetering back to my ant form, I retreated to a forest of grass, whipping past the blades as I shot on my way at a speed that only a god could master in silent movement.

Ty. I would remember him. For a minute. And then he would be gone like so many others from my mind. They only entertained me briefly as I moved on to other, more important matters. Perhaps that was how Ty’s friend thought of him?

I took pause by a puddle of water, collecting a bead of it at the surface to sip from as ants were want to do. My antenna twitched, fervent in their restlessness. I turned my head from the left to the right, struggling to still them. Their movement was not from conscious direction and something deeper thrummed through my heart, dread curling between the bones of my ribcage to *squeeze*.

Shaking myself, I peered through the grass stems, cupping dark shadows where the blaze of the sun did not reach. The sun drifted behind a cloud, casting the world into a grey hue that could not be of my imagination. My form shivered, threatening to break apart, and a cold chill trickled down my spine. That had never happened before.

Swaying, I struggled to balance, tipping forward over the water as if about to fall in and scramble for life. I had always been so sure of myself. My stomach churned, bile rising in a throat incapable of vomiting, forcing me to contain every vile drop.

Was there any point to any of this? I blinked at my reflection in the puddle, seeing far more than any normal ant ever would. Black, round head, the rise of antenna, caught in constant twitching. I was nothing, nothing at all. Just an ant that a human could step on at any time, crush underfoot and then that would be that, if I was at my weakest: no more god. And what good had I ever done as a god? Playing a god? I backed away from the puddle and would have widened my eyes in horror if I had possessed the correct facial muscles and structure. As it was, I reeled mentally as if struck plain across the face. Would I ever be satisfied?

What had I done to that poor wolf? That lone soul now had not a word in life or love going for him. Instead of considering his death with potent relish, it turned my stomach to think of him swinging from the tree, hangman to his own noose. He swung and he swung, back and forth back and forth, seasons changing about him. The hollow sockets of his eyes turned to face me, a gaping cave of decay.

I threw my body backwards, away from thought, turning about and fleeing in a direction I could not discern. For all I knew, in that moment, I could have been running in circles, a tiny being lost amongst the heel of the world. And yet it was no more than I deserved, my lot in life and playing with life. My power seemed a far cry from my grasp, fled to a dark corner where I feared it would never return. Was this what it was like to have completely depleted every ounce of strength a god could claim? Was this what it was to be...*mortal*?

Screaming, no sound burst from me, and I collapsed into the dirt, a minute imprint in time that all would forget, all too swiftly. What good was exercising so much power in but a minute, what good was the capability, when all it did was land me in the dust with a shard of glass driven into my gut? Every ounce had been depleted on that sorry black wolf and his sorry life. Depression would have taken him even if I had not intervened and yet I had foolishly spent every scrap, more energy than the deed should have even taken, on ensuring he would slit his throat before the day was out. I wasted myself on entertainment. And now I was nothing. The lack of left me as nothing.

I swallowed mentally, dragging myself up on unsteady legs, feet skating through slick, oozing mud. If I could play such ill on one with power I had never earned... Well, could anyone have said any different of me? The pit of my heart wrenched. It was abused and now it was lost to me, lost forever. In one last. The loss of my power could mean only one thing to my stricken mind, darkness seeping in from the edges and racing with increasing speed towards the centre of my being.

I deserved to die.

What god such as I had the right to continue in a facsimile of life?

Why did I think I had any remaining right to enjoy the life of Earth and all she contained?

Cold and dark, miles underground. I imagined maggots devouring my skin – what form would be best suited to death? – wearing a void of a mortal body down to the very bones that made it up, only for those too to crack under the weight of time. The wind picked up, bending the blades of grass as the world around me threatened to take flight, leaving me behind. I would preferred the wind to drag my clinging form from the dirt and toss me upon its claws until there was nothing left. Only then would I have satisfied and atoned for what I had done. My corpse would be beautiful. Death itself was an art. I would only ever do it exceptionally well.

Death... Would she be kind?

No, no... I took the form of a bird – a common black crow – and hurled myself into the air, beating up and away from stray feathers as a caw ripped itself from my beak. Survival! Life! I had to survive! I would not be as those common mortals, toys at the tips of my feathers. Stretching out my wings to catch the updraft, I beat furiously, gaining height more quickly than any crow should. I was not a crow. I was a god. I was stronger than a crow. I was weaker than a god.

I was a *god*.

Until I was a god no more.

Gods provide. Gods prosper. Gods protect. I had completed none of those tasks.

No being could live up to this vast expectation – not a single one. It was impossible. The weight of what I was put in the world to do bore down on me, an invisible wind buffeting me plain in the beak. Tumbling beak over feet in midair, my form wavered, threatening to break, and I pushed on, regaining my flight path with a monumental effort and screaming twist of muscle.

Screeching a soulless cry to the rising turmoil of blackening storm clouds, I laughed humourlessly at the odd, disparaging shaft of sunlight slanting through. It was as if the sun made to give a beam of hope where darkness roiled, twisting and yawning. Those rays were futile. If I was fading, we were all waiting to be devoured in the maw of eternity.

All was lost, all was dark and I was dead inside.

My wing beats grew weaker and weaker until I barely kept myself aloft, dipping to the level of the trees and lower. Paying no attention to my flight, I forced myself to keep going out of habit and abject perseverance. I had somewhere to be and yet I did not know where that was.

Without conscious thought, I flew my soul to a reservoir blocked into a valley, flooded for the sole purpose of providing mortals with life sustaining water. Closing my eyes, I dipped my flight with a ‘caw’ and tucked my wings in close to my feathered sides for a shallow dive. It was too easy to fall. If I did not think about it too carefully, I could have simply left my wings in close to my body and fallen and fallen and fallen.

Plummeting to the grass, I drove myself to a spot near the highest point of the damn where nature melded into that which had been constructed by a mortal's hand. Or paw. Or hoof. There were many anthropomorphic creatures these days. All of my own design. My own, hasty, petty design.

I pressed my beak into the grass, dirt clogging up my 'nares. My body shifted, out of my control, and I became a grey mouse with a furred tail and twitching, pink nose. My whiskers quivered, alert to the slightest change in wind direction, and I shrank into prey, small and worthless in the middle of nowhere. Cowering into the dirt, my misdeeds crowded my mind, each and every one demanding attention in the rancour of my head. Too much – all at once! I whimpered. All too much to take in, how could one being cope with it all? I did not even think of how I had been able to shift forms, not once but twice, with threads of power far, far beyond my reach, a distant dream. It did not matter. Nothing mattered any more. That poor wolf.

Perhaps I had one last power. One to end my reign. I closed my eyes and knew what I had to do.

The waters beckoned. Such a sweet tune, rushing water. A portion of the dam had been opened, allowing a stream to flow straight down from the highest point, crashing into release and dying an instant death in the body of a river. Where it brought life, it carried death, each droplet living and dying in the fleetest of moments, a heartbeat heard through a lover's parted lips. But that fall of water not where my nose quested towards. I faced the reservoir itself where the water was quieter, awaiting its call.

I heralded my call.

It was too late, it was much too late for me.

Crawling to the edge of the reservoir, I peered over the edge of the stone to the dark, lapping water below. Too little too late, as they always said. Or so I had heard the humans and furries talk, talk, talk, talk in their endless jabber of life. My heart, if I had had a heart, would have twisted. Yet, as it was, the emptiness in my chest spread, hollowness seeping through the fibre of my being so that I no longer felt seated in my form, essence wavering like my resolve.

I was tired. Oh, so very tired. And my time on earth...what good had that done? I closed my eyes against the glare of sunlight, nose twitching as a group of younger humans raced past me, trainer-clad feet slapping the pavement. Unusual. I would have thought such a far out reservoir would have been quieter. Deserted. The ground vibrated as they passed and I leaned out further over the edge, recklessly throwing myself away. But, like the wolf, there was no persuading me otherwise with the mere presence of another. The end would come. If there was nothing I could do for a lone individual, one of my craftsmanship and creation, why should I preserve my own body for a second longer?

My head spun. There was no point. The wolf's face danced mockingly in my mind's eye, an eon of memory forcing me to remember more clearly than I would have liked to remember anything at all, the sad tilt to his head and the look in his eye as he plodded away, weariness lining the tread of his step. I hadn't been able to help him. I hadn't been able to help anyone, not a single soul in the world I laughing toyed with, drafting new for my own wicked

amusement. The furries themselves – if I had not created them, the wolf would have never existed to die. For was that not the reason that any of them were alive in the first place? There was no reason to them. The wind played with my whiskers and I allowed it, myself a toy to the elements. It was all one such as I deserved.

Power? The notion of my power was laughable. Lonely. Depressing.

The wind picked up, whipping into a frenzy about my tiny mouse form, black eyes snapping open. Beady. I should have been a rat, infesting with illness, death, as I stalked the sewers, sliding through piles of my own excrement coupled with that of the world. It was more of an existence than I had earned, than I deserved in my life. It was not a life. I had no life.

I swayed, losing my grip on the stone as life fled from me in a whisper of black curled upon the wind. Sickness plummeted to the pit of my stomach and I reeled, spinning, claws scrabbling on rock and then – nothingness. Empty air.

I fell.

No one saw the mouse teetering and tumbling to an untimely fate, the drop too far for a mammal of my size to survive in its natural state. Scarred, grey stone flickered by as I dropped, dropped, dropped for an age, air whistling in my ears. The breeze tickled my fur and I had time in my fall to take note of the imperfections in the stone, coarse and uneven where it had been cut inefficiently. A tuft of black fur was tucked between two blocks, an impossible location for it to have been there by mortal intervention.

My eyes closed a fraction of a second before I hit the water and was engulfed by my end. The last thing I saw was the wolf's muzzle curve into a smile, hope lighting up his eyes in a sparkle of blue. It could have been the last time he had smiled in his life or it could have been a figment of my imagination. One day, perhaps I would know which one it was.

The water swallowed me, hungry for my sodden form. Impact snapped my spine like a twig. The wolf threw his head back and laughed. My soul split. I was gone.

Pulling the mouse body deeper, the reservoir took him into its hungry jaws, closing around a hunk of meat that was no longer good for anything in the waking world. The wolf's smile twisted into a smirk, blue eyes darkening to sapphire, but it was too late for the regrets of a fallen god.

Racing through matter, my soul drifted without meaning or purpose, seeking something it did not know how to find. Would I ever know what had become of the wolf? What world he had ended up in after his untimely demise? Only time would tell, that slow trickling of sand through the hourglass as I dug up my purpose from life, if what I had left to me was a life at all. The wolf may yet be redeemed. I may yet be redeemed. The fabric of the other world called me, tantalising in her song. What could a fallen god do but to heed her call and race into her arms?

I was as much at the whim of creation as the wolf I'd killed.